

SOLAR PUSH
Karnataka energy minister K.J. George (left) reviews a solarisation initiative for agricultural pumps in Hassan

ment allocated Rs 10,000 crore to the energy department. The present regime has not released any grants as it does not have money," former CM Basavaraj Bommai said at a farmers' protest on October 11. In turn, the Congress, which was voted into office in May, points out that Karnataka did not create any additional generation capacity in the last four years of BJP rule. "For four years, they did not add any power to the grid or sign any power purchase agreement. Now they are blaming us," says George, who met Union power minister R.K. Singh last fortnight to seek additional power allocation from central generating stations.

To tide over the current crisis, the government is negotiating power-swapping arrangements with Uttar Pradesh and Punjab, besides buying power from exchanges. Meanwhile, it has invoked Section 11 of the Electricity Act, 2003, to commandeer power from open access generators in the state, which will likely yield an additional 1,000-1,500 MW.

In the longer term, the state is banking on fast-tracking the solarisation of electricity sub-stations and agricultural pumps under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyan (PM-KUSUM) scheme. Around 400 sub-stations have been identified for solarisation by setting up solar parks nearby to meet agricultural demand. Meanwhile, there's also a cabinet nod to increase the state's share of subsidy offered to farmers for installing solar pump sets. In the first phase, the target is to cover 100,000 of the state's 3.4 million agricultural pumps, according to a senior official. "They will get power supply in the daytime and without any dependency on grid," he says. There are currently 6,801 solar pump sets in the state. "A big chunk of power is going to irrigation. Once we take care of the irrigation pump sets, there will automatically be excess power," says George. "The solarisation (of sub-stations) can happen within 8-10 months or one year. Next year, this problem will not be there," he adds.

KARNATAKA HAS POWER-SWAPPING ARRANGEMENTS WITH UP AND PUNJAB AND IS FAST-TRACKING SOLARISATION

The deficit in rainfall between June and September meant that farmers began using irrigation pump sets earlier than usual to save standing crops, causing demand to peak. In September 2022, demand from pumps was around 900 million units but it shot up to 2,000 million units this year, says the official. At the same time, hydel reservoirs were running low on storage, leading to a generation loss of 2,970 million units, or four per cent of the state's annual demand.

Among long-gestation projects, the state is looking at pumped storage hydropower—in which water is stored at a higher-elevation secondary reservoir and released into turbines to generate power on demand. The government, says George, is also keen to speed up plans for a pit-head thermal power plant in Chhattisgarh where the state has invested in land. "If the plan we have drawn up is implemented, there will be no problem at all," says George.

The immediate concern is to manage the demand surges, given that high demand for irrigation pump sets lasts up to end-November. At a recent meeting, chief minister Siddaramaiah asked officials to ensure five hours of power supply to farmers. The hope is that the situation will ease over the next month. But bringing in efficient processes for energy supply and getting long-gestation projects going will be key to managing the growing power demand. ■